

EXCLUSIVE

IAS PRELIMS 2026

CURRENT AFFAIRS

REVISION

GS-1 (DYNAMIC)

MODULE – 99



**POLITY & OTHER
NATIONAL
EVENTS – 16**



THE TRANSGENDER PERSONS (PROTECTION OF RIGHTS) AMENDMENT ACT, 2026 REACHED DELHI HIGH COURT

- There were two petitions filed in Delhi High Court against the Transgenders Amendment Act, 2026, claiming that the amendment replaces self-identified gender identity recognized by the Supreme Court with the state-determined identity through medical and administrative process.
- As per the petitioners, the original 2019 Act was enacted to implement the Supreme Court's recognition of transgender rights. The 2026 amendment fundamentally alters this framework by introducing medical and administrative verification of gender identity.
- The petitioners also contended that, this shift violates constitutional guarantees under Articles 14, 19 (1) (a) and 21, and amounts to a legislative rollback of a fundamental right already recognized by the Supreme Court.

The Supreme Court recognized transgender persons as a third gender long ago.

MEANING OF IMPORTANT TERMS

TRANSGENDER

A transgender person is one whose gender does not match the gender assigned at birth. It includes trans-men and trans-women, persons with intersex variations.



TRANS MAN

A trans man is a man sexed as "female" at birth, who identifies and lives as a man.

TRANS WOMAN

A trans woman is a woman, who was sexed "male" at birth, who identifies and lives as a woman.

TRANSSEXUAL

A transsexual is a person who feels he or she belongs to the opposite sex.

INTER-SEX VARIATIONS

Inter-sex is defined to mean a person, who at birth shows variation in his or her primary sexual characteristics, external genitalia, chromosomes, or hormones from the normative standard of male or female body.



NALSA VERSUS UNION OF INDIA ... SUPREME COURT JUDGMENT 2014

- Supreme Court held that the right to gender identity is inherent in one's right to life, autonomy and dignity.
- Transgender persons have the right to identify their gender as male, female or transgender irrespective of medical sex reassignment and the right to expression of their chosen gender identity.
- It directed the Central and State Govts. to grant legal recognition of gender identity of male, female or transgender. It also directed to provide reservations to transgender persons, along with other directions.

TRANSGENDER PERSONS (PROTECTION OF RIGHTS) ACT, 2019



SALIENT FEATURES

6 Every establishment will have to appoint a **Complaints Officer** to deal with **complaints related to violation of the provisions.**

5 **NCTP will include five members from the transgender community and five experts from non-governmental organisations** along with representations of NITI Aayog and the National Human Rights Commission. It will be an **Advisory Body.**

4 The Central Government will set up the **National Council for Transgender Persons** and this will be headed by the **Union Minister for Social Justice** as the Chairperson.

1 Transgender person has the right to **self-perceived gender identity.**

2 It **prohibits discrimination** against a transgender person, on grounds including **denial, discontinuation or unfair treatment in educational institutions, services, employment etc.**

3 Transgender person will have to make an **application to the District Magistrate**, who will issue a certificate of identity to the transgender person. This will be the proof, that the person is a transgender.

1

DEFINITION OF A TRANSGENDER PERSON



- The 2019 Act defines a transgender person as a person whose gender does not match with the gender assigned at birth and specifies certain persons who are included.
- The 2026 Amendment removes this definition. It instead lists categories of persons to be included.
- The bill also states that it will not include or will never have included persons with different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities.

SALIENT FEATURES OF THE TRANSGENDER PERSONS PROTECTION OF RIGHTS (AMENDMENT) ACT, 2026

1

DEFINITION OF A TRANSGENDER PERSON

INCLUSION UNDER TRANSGENDERS

- A person with socio-cultural identity such as Kinner, Hijra, Aravani, or Jogta.
- A person with variations at birth in characteristics such as primary sexual characteristics, external genitalia, chromosomes, or hormones from the normative standard of male or female body.
- Eunuch and a person who is forced to assume a transgender identity by mutilation, emasculation, castration, surgical, chemical, or hormonal procedures.

THE FOLLOWING CATEGORIES WERE REMOVED

A trans-man or trans-woman, irrespective of whether such a person has undergone sex reassignment surgery, hormone therapy, laser therapy, or such other therapy, and gender queer.



2

RECOGNITION OF TRANSGENDER IDENTITY

- Under the 2019 Act, a transgender person may apply to the district magistrate for issuing a certificate of identity as a transgender person.
- The 2026 Amendment adds that the district magistrate will issue the certificate after examining the recommendation of a designated medical board. The board will be headed by a chief medical officer or a deputy chief medical officer. The district magistrate may take assistance of other medical experts.
- The bill adds that the transgender persons will be entitled to change the first name in the birth certificate and other official documents based on the certificate of identity.

3

CHANGE IN GENDER

- The 2019 Act provides that a revised certificate of identity may be obtained where a transgender person undergoes surgery to change gender.
- The 2026 Amendment instead mandates the person to obtain a revised certificate after concerned medical institution furnishing the information regarding the gender change surgery to the district magistrate.



4

OFFENCES AND PENALTIES



- Under the 2019 Act, offences against transgender persons include:
 - ✓ Compelling or enticing into forced or bonded labor.
 - ✓ Denying the right of passage or obstructing use of public places.These are punishable with imprisonment between six months and two years and a fine.
- The 2026 Amendment adds certain offenses like kidnapping and causing grievous hurt or severe injury in order to force a person to assume a transgender identity. It will carry:
 - ✓ Imprisonment between 10 years and life and a minimum fine of 2 lakh rupees, if the victim is an adult.
 - ✓ Imprisonment for life and fine of at least 5 lakh rupees, if the victim is a child.



The fund marks a paradigm shift in India's urban development approach from grant-based financing to market-linked, reform-driven, and outcome-oriented infrastructure creation.

URBAN CHALLENGE FUND WAS CLEARED BY THE UNION CABINET

- The Union Cabinet recently approved the launch of the Urban Challenge Fund (UCF), a new centrally sponsored scheme of the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry with Rs. 1 lakh crore central assistance.
- The Government said, the scheme aimed to support transformative and bankable urban projects through a competitive challenge mode, as urban infrastructure could not be developed with public finance alone.
- Central assistance will cover 25% of the project costs subject to raising a minimum of 50% of the project costs from the market, including municipal bonds, bank loans, and public-private partnerships leading to an expected investment of Rs. 4 lakh crore in the urban sector over the next five years.

OTHER IMPORTANT ASPECTS PERTAINING TO THE URBAN CHALLENGE FUND



- The fund will cover cities with a population of 10 lakh or more (based on 2025 estimates), all capitals of States and Union Territories and major industrial cities with a population of 1 lakh or more.
- Additionally, all urban local bodies in hilly states and northeastern states and the smaller urban local bodies with a population below 1 lakh will be eligible for support under the Credit Repayment Guarantee Scheme.
- Under the Credit Repayment Guarantee Scheme, the Centre will provide a guarantee of up to Rs. 7 crore or 70% of the loan amount, whichever is lower for first time loans.
- A dedicated Rs. 5,000 crore corpus will enhance the credit worthiness of 4,223 cities, including tier-2 and tier-3 cities, particularly for first time access to market finance.
- The fund will be operational from the financial year 2025-26 to 2030-31 with an extendable implementation period up to 2033-34.

Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) struggle to complete unfinished work under other schemes, including AMRUT, Swachh Bharat Mission Urban 2.0, Smart Cities and Pradhan Mantri Aavas Yojana, which suffer from chronic underutilization.

What do you know about India hosting the 2030 Commonwealth Games (CWG)?



- The Commonwealth Games will return to India after a gap of 20 years, with Ahmedabad hosting the 2030 centenary edition. Commonwealth Sport (CS) recently approved the proposal in favour of Ahmedabad ahead of the Nigerian capital city Abuja.
- This opportunity gives India a boost to its ambition to bid for the 2036 Olympics. It is incidental to note that India has submitted the letter of intent to host the 2036 Olympics with Ahmedabad as the front runner.
- At the same time, the CWG is struggling for relevance in the post-colonial world. In 2022, Birmingham replaced Durban, whereas Glasgow came to the rescue for 2026 after the Australian state of Victoria withdrew. Now Ahmedabad stepped in for the Canadian province of Alberta.

India has won 61, 66, 64, 101 medals in the last four editions. In the subsequent Olympics, it has secured just 6, 7, 2 and 6 medals respectively.

What do you know about the Indian Women Cricket Team clinching the recent world championship?



- Women cricket team led by Harmanpreet Kaur, finally crowned world champions in women's cricket. In Navi Mumbai's DY Patil Stadium, India defeated South Africa by 52 runs and won their maiden Women's World Cup title. India reached World Cup finals in 2005 and 2017 but lost in the finals.
- The defending champions Australia was defeated in the semi-finals. The women's team is set to win Rs. 90 crore in prize money and cash rewards.
- In 2022, the BCCI introduced equal match fees for both women and men players across all three formats of the sport. Women's Cricket Premier League was formed in 2023.

The prize money is \$4.48 million that came from the International Cricket Council, the world's governing body.



- Aroma Mission was started in J&K and aims to boost India's aroma industry by enhancing the cultivation of aromatic crops and production of essential oils. It is popularly known as the Lavender Revolution.
- Aromatic crops (like rose, peppermint) are plants grown for their fragrant oils, used in industries like cosmetics, aromatherapy, and food flavoring.
- The mission focuses on the cultivation of high-value aroma crops such as lemongrass, lavender, vetiver, palmarosa and others.
- The nodal agency is the CSIR-Central Institute of Medicinal and Aromatic Plants (CSIR-CIMAP), Lucknow.

The Ministry of Science and Technology said that the Northeast Region, as well as Jammu and Kashmir, have been on the priority list for the Aroma Mission.



UNION CABINET APPROVED BHAVYA

- Union Cabinet recently approved Rs. 33,660 crore Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA) scheme to develop 100 plug-and-play industrial parks.
- It is considered a significant step towards strengthening India's manufacturing base, promoting job creation and improving facilitating business.
- Spread over about 33,000 acres and to be implemented in more than six years, these parks will provide pre-approved land, ready infrastructure and integrated services supported by robust single-window clearance systems and deregulation measures led by states.

Estimates suggest it could generate around 1.5 million direct jobs while strengthening domestic supply chains through cluster-based development.

SALIENT FEATURES OF THE Rs. 33,660 CRORE BHAVYA SCHEME

At the heart of this program is strong push for deregulation and ease of doing business with the streamlined approvals, effective single window systems and investor friendly reforms led by the states.



- The aim of the scheme is to create 100 future-ready industrial parks that will integrate with the PM Gati Shakti program so that they can avail of that program's multi-modal connectivity and last-mile access.
- These parks will set new benchmarks in industrial infrastructure, ensuring reliability, reducing inefficiencies, and enhancing productivity across sectors. The scheme duration would be for six years starting in 2026-27.
- The first phase of development would see 50 parks being set up. The minimum land required for the parks would be 100 acres in most cases and 25 acres for industrial parks in hilly or northeastern states. The maximum size under the scheme is 1,000 acres.
- While the Central Government will provide funding of up to Rs. 1 crore per acre, the scheme is meant to include the involvement of the respective state governments as well as the private sector.

THERE ARE SOME EXAMPLES IN FRONT OF US!



- Industrial nodes such as the Dholera Special Investment Region, the Shendra-Bidkin Industrial Area, Vikram Udyogpuri, and the Greater Noida Industrial Area highlight the potential of plug-and-play ecosystems, where pre-approved land, integrated infrastructure and multimodal connectivity enable faster industrialisation.
- The National Industrial Corridor Development Corporation, which is implementing 20 projects across 13 states, has demonstrated how such models can attract both Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) and large businesses by reducing entry barriers and improving project readiness.



TWO IMPORTANT DIRECTIVES BY DoT

1

SIM BINDING

- The apps such as WhatsApp, Telegram, Signal, Arattai, Snapchat, etc. must ensure that Subscriber Identity Module (SIM) cards are continuously linked to respective services. This is known as SIM binding.
- If users opt for website or web app-based access, the apps must ensure they are logged out every six hours and re-login through the QR code.
- The rationale for SIM binding is that apps like these may allow access even when the underlying SIM is not present or active. It has been argued that this creates vulnerabilities that may be exploited to commit cyber fraud.
- This is to be implemented from February 2026.

WHAT IS THE CRITICS VIEWPOINT OF THIS MANDATE GIVEN BY DoT?



- This directive will interfere in the functionality of these apps and disrupt the business models of many services provided on them as well as cause inconvenience to a large number of individual users. The apps are already bound to devices, while subscribers sign up for accounts by using the SIM.
- One of the most useful functions is that these apps allow communication even when the SIM is not active. Some obvious use cases are for mariners at sea or persons (such as oil prospectors, defence personnel) working in remote areas where a SIM-based telecom network is not present, but Wi-Fi connectivity is available.
- The SIM binding directive would also disrupt the provision of WhatsApp business accounts, where multiple persons using different devices log in using the same business account.
- Hence, this directive could obviously be disruptive to many users, including businesses and interfere in core features of messaging apps.

2

PRE-INSTALLATION OF SANCHAR SAATHI APP

As per critics, it is potentially a backdoor into every device on which it is installed, and it could enable government surveillance on a larger scale.



- The smartphone manufacturers must pre-install the Sanchar Saathi App to verify device authenticity in all new devices by March 2026. This is intended to protect smartphone devices, verify International Mobile Equipment Identity (IMEI) number, and report suspicious activities.
- Developed by the government, it has features like Chakshu, which allows users to report suspected fraud attempts, by call, SMS or WhatsApp, including impersonation, financial scams, and spoofed calls.
- The app also helps users report lost and stolen phones, which can then be traced or disabled. Users may also use the app to check if any unauthorized mobile connection has been issued in their names.
- It requires permission to handle call and SMS logs, phone management, SMS sending, camera and file access, and location.

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